

Theropods

Theropods were the world's top predators throughout much of the dinosaurs' reign. This branch of the dinosaur family tree gave rise to some truly gigantic carnivores (although not all were meat-eaters). A selection of these immense animals is shown here. Interestingly, one group of theropods would evolve into the birds that share our world today.



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Long skulls with large eye sockets, and often horns or crests on top
- Air-filled bones
- Many had a furcula, or wishbone. Birds today have this feature.
- Immense jaws with curved teeth
- Strong arms with three-fingered hands
- Three-toed feet

When

Theropods flourished from the Late Triassic to the Late Cretaceous (230–65 million years ago).



▲ THEROPODS walked on immense hind legs, using a stiff, muscular tail to balance the great weight of a massive head and fang-lined jaws.